Chapter 9: Beat the Enemy. Then, Heal the Enemy.

Both teams Aschelle and Terrian cleared the field, and York called for the next fight, Alfir verses Ramere.

Since it wasn't a large demand Ramere was making, only three verses three were called to fight.

Ramere sent Roy, their team captain, as was required, Dixon, and Lucas. Alfir's team captain was part elf and fought with a great sword. He brought a part troll and part wind nymph with him. Alfir was always interesting to watch as they didn't just have war mage abilities, they had abilities from their races and familiars, although familiars weren't allowed in battle.

Roy fought with katars, and his team did incredibly well, but they couldn't compete with the speed of a half-elf, the strength of a part-ogre, or the wind control of the nymph.

Ramere ended up losing.

Everyone was shocked when York stood up and

announced, “Alfir has won.” That was normal, but he followed with, “I announced before that there is now a penalty for those who attack and lose, so we will punish the captain of team Ramere.”

Gasps went through the crowd.

York quieted them. “I know, it’s sad to see blood drawn, but if there is nothing for teams to lose if they attack and lose, they will attack frivolously.”

“But I don’t make the decisions to attack,” Roy called up to him. “This isn’t fair. Punish the councilmen who decide the attacks, not the team captains. This isn’t…”

“Silence!” York ordered. “Since this is the first time for punishment for losing, I will only call for ten lashes. If you fight, it will be doubled.”

Roy tensed, but said nothing. Several lesser war mages from Aschelle came to escort him to be punished.

As his shirt was removed, he looked over, hoping to be struck with a normal whip, but he wasn’t so fortunate. A lesser war mage with a magical whip stood ready to strike.

Roy wished he could fight the man. Likely, he could beat him, but if he fought, he’d take twice the punishment. There was nothing he could do.

The lesser war mage, hit hard, and Roy couldn’t help but scream out in pain.

Most of the crowd was shocked, and many couldn’t watch. Sure, they were used to fighting, but to gems dark,

not to seeing a man with his gem dark whipped and bloodied.

There were some who seemed to enjoy it, calling out, “We want blood.”

When the beating was over, Roy was helped off the field and York announced, “It’s sad punishment must happen, but to stop the war, it’s needed, and I know we all want the war to stop.”

Ramere called in response, “We want blood!”

York quieted them and announced, “The next battle will be between Phyrn and Terrian. Phyrn is attacking to get Bruis and Xena back.”

“We don’t have Xena,” Rhys called back.

“Then you will take her place,” York insisted.

“Wait!” Hrod called up.

York turned to him, shocked someone besides the team captain was addressing him.

Yet, Hrod defended, “Hold the fight for Xena until next battle day. They are attacking for two people, and that should require two fights, but we’ve already fought and we don’t have Xena, so please, put that off until her disappearance can be investigated.”

York thought for a moment and decided, “No. But since there are two people to be returned, this will be a team verses team fight, ten on ten.”

The crowd gasped. Fights were always only a few

war mages. Five verses five was huge.

“Take the field,” York instructed.

“Wait!” a voice called. Everyone was shocked they turned to see it was the captain of the team from Cruia. “Terrian did not give Xena asylum. We did.”

All eyes went to him. Cruia seldom fought. They mostly stayed out of the war. Yet, Boran, the team captain was admitting to having Xena.

York called Slayde, the captain from Phyrn, over to discuss the battles. After a few minutes, he announced, “There will be a three on three, Phyrn verses Terrian, battle. Then, if Slayde still has light in his gem, there will be a battle, Phyrn verses Cruia.”

The crowd gasped, as they weren’t used to seeing Cruia fight, but York calmed them and announced, “Terrian, Phyrn, take the field.”

Rhys did have glow in his gem, thanks to Catria’s healing. Rhys led Blake, and Eoin onto the field. Slayde let Grunth and Gorn.

“Prepare to die!” Slayde hissed at Rhys as the teams took their sides.

Rhys met his eyes with defiance. Showing fear to a Phyrnian was never wise.

They stayed with their eyes locked until York called for the battle to start.

No one could fight past gems, as the stakes weren’t any of the war mages’ lives, but Phyrn was determined to

get Bruis back, and Terrian really didn't want to return him. He was brutal in battle, and he'd broken their law.

The fight was intense, and Rhys could tell that Slayde didn't want to just win. He wanted blood.

Slayde fought with a shoge, a chain with a metal ring on one end and a knife with a hook on it on the other. It was a powerful weapon against a sword, as the chain could entangle the sword and the hook was used to trap it.

Yet, Aiden knew he had the advantage close up, so he blasted Slayde with fire and charged in.

Gorn was the first out. He was good, but Blake was good at deflecting his twin daggers with his kamas and counter striking.

Eoin was the next out. He was incredible with his twin chakrams, but Grunth had the strength that any time he did hit, Eoins shielding went down quickly.

That matched Blake and Grunth up, and Blake's speed with his kamas against Grunth's stand and strike mace won. Grunth had to leave.

That made it so Blake could help Rhys. Rhys needed the help. His gem was very low when Blake arrived. He was able to strike and grab the chain with his kamas so Slayde couldn't strip Rhys's sword from him. Yet Slayde struck with the knife as Rhys struck with his sword. Both of them brought the other's shielding down.

Blake was left with his slightly glowing, so Terrian won.

York announced, “Terrian has won. Cruia and Phyrn will now take the field.”

Slayde called up to him, “I cannot fight, as my shielding is down. Permission to not fight with my team?”

York thought for a moment, then ordered, “Catria, you can heal him. Do. The rules say that captain must fight, but they also say no one may fight if his gem is dark. I want you to heal him, as it will satisfy both rules.”

Everyone gasped. Someone on one war mage team healing another team’s player so he could fight was unheard of. Sure, she healed Aiden so he didn’t die, but she didn’t want to heal Slayde so he could injure a Cruian war mage.”

“What if I say no?” Catria asked.

York’s eyes burned through her as he answered, “The penalty for disobeying the head of the arena is punishment. You will be beaten.”